

Israel/Palestine

In 2002, the NYPD established the Demographics Unit, renamed the Zone Assessment Unit, to surveil Muslim New Yorkers on the basis of their faith and/or ethnicity or national origins. The Unit used multiple methods to spy on and monitor Muslim communities without any suspicion of wrongdoing, including photo and video surveillance and employing “mosque crawlers”, informants who were instructed to instigate conversations about jihad and terrorism and report back to the NYPD.

The Demographics Unit was heavily inspired by Israeli surveillance of Palestinians in the occupied Palestinian Territories. Shortly after 9/11, a delegation of New York officials toured Israel to exchange “best practices”. Exchanges between Israeli and American police forces continue into the present. Al Jazeera reported that Larry Sanchez, the architect of the Demographics Unit, based the Unit’s methods on Israeli surveillance in the West Bank. While whistleblowers reject the claim that Israeli forces are teaching the NYPD how to be racist, they emphasize that these exchanges amplify and validate the most abusive practices of all of the organizations involved. In the case of the Demographics Unit, Israeli surveillance methods in the West Bank gave NYPD officers concrete examples of how to secretly surveil, infiltrate, and monitor communities based on their affiliation to a particular nationality, ethnicity, and/or religion.

Mohamed Bahe is part of a Muslim volunteer group, the Muslims Giving Back food drive, and he was a victim of the Demographics Unit’s surveillance. In 2012, he noticed cops were trailing him; later, a member of the group confessed to being a paid NYPD informant. After the news went public, Bahe and his group were banned from their mosque out of fear of surveillance and volunteers left in droves. Bahe was isolated from his community and temporarily had to cease any work with his food bank.

Muslims Giving Back sued the NYPD. The lawsuit was settled and the NYPD agreed to curtail its surveillance of New York’s Muslim community, but to this day continues to deny that a surveillance program that targeted Muslims ever existed.

In 2014, the NYPD officially disbanded the Zone Assessment Unit, formerly known as the Demographics Unit. Since 2011 when AP published a report detailing the Unit’s existence and activities to the public, New Yorkers and civil rights groups called for its closing. However, NYPD official statements did not confirm Unit’s duties had not been reassigned to a different part of the NYPD. Detectives in the Unit were reassigned to other positions within the NYPD.

Citations:

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